

AMITH ANANTHRAM

amith@cs.columbia.edu · (703) 509-0397 · Brooklyn, NY · amith-ananthram.github.io

RESEARCH INTERESTS

How data and reward signals shape model behavior: pre-training data, post-training reward functions and evals in LLMs and VLMs. Focus areas: AI safety (poisoning, bias) and the limits of language-mediated vision.

EDUCATION

Columbia University, New York, NY expected completion: 2026
PhD in Computer Science (NLP/CV), advised by Professor Kathleen McKeown (GPA: 4.0/4.0)

Columbia University, New York, NY 2020
MS in Computer Science, with a concentration in NLP (GPA: 4.11/4.0)

Dartmouth College, Hanover, NH 2014
BA (GPA: 3.63/4.0, Cum Laude)

Majors (3): Computer Science, Classical Languages & Literature, Economics

Thomas Jefferson HS for Science and Technology, Alexandria, VA 2010

PUBLICATIONS

- [1] **PoSh: Using Scene Graphs to Guide LLMs-as-a-Judge for Detailed Image Descriptions.** *ICLR 2026*. [Amith Ananthram](#), Elias Stengel-Eskin, Lorena A. Bradford, Julia Demarest, Adam Purvis, Keith Krut, Rina Elster Pantalony, Mohit Bansal, Kathleen McKeown.
- [2] **Mining Contextualized Visual Associations from Images for Creativity Understanding.** *INLG 2025 (Best Long Paper)*. Ananya Sahu, [Amith Ananthram](#), Kathleen McKeown.
- [3] **See It from My Perspective: How Language Affects Cultural Bias in Image Understanding.** *ICLR 2025*. [Amith Ananthram](#), Elias Stengel-Eskin, Mohit Bansal, Kathleen McKeown.
- [4] **Data Caricatures: On the Representation of African American Language in Pretraining Corpora.** *ACL 2025*. Nicholas Deas, Blake Vente, [Amith Ananthram](#), Jessica A. Grieser, Desmond Patton, Shana Kleiner, James Shepard, Kathleen McKeown.
- [5] **Enhancing Multimodal Affective Analysis with Learned Live Comment Features.** *AAAI 2025*. Zhaoyuan Deng, [Amith Ananthram](#), Kathleen McKeown.
- [6] **Social Orientation: A New Feature for Dialogue Analysis.** *LREC-COLING 2024*. Todd Morrill, Zhaoyuan Deng, Yanda Chen, [Amith Ananthram](#), Colin Wayne Leach, Kathleen McKeown.
- [7] **FeelingBlue: A Corpus for Understanding the Emotional Connotation of Color in Context.** *TACL 2023*, presented at *ACL 2023*. [Amith Ananthram](#), Olivia Winn, Smaranda Muresan.
- [8] **Check-COVID: Fact-Checking News Claims with Scientific Evidence.** *ACL 2023 (Findings)*. Gengyu Wang, Kate Harwood, [Amith Ananthram](#), Melanie Subbiah, Kathleen McKeown.
- [9] **Seeded Hierarchical Clustering for Expert-Crafted Taxonomies.** *EMNLP 2022 (Findings)*. Anish Saha, [Amith Ananthram](#), Emily Allaway, Heng Ji, Kathleen McKeown.
- [10] **Event-Guided Denoising for Multilingual Relation Learning.** *COLING 2020*. [Amith Ananthram](#), Emily Allaway, Kathleen McKeown.

WORK EXPERIENCE

Anthropic, Berkeley, CA Aug 2026 – Nov 2026
Research Fellow

- Working on frontier AI safety research
- Running controlled, multi-seed experiments (synthetic corpus generation, pre/mid-training on models up to 7B parameters, SFT/DPO, LLM-judged evals), automated with coding agents

Stripe, San Francisco, CA
Software Engineer (Levels 2–3)

Feb 2018 – Aug 2019

- Technical lead for rolling cash reserves on merchant accounts, a way for Stripe to hold a fixed percentage of merchant processing volume on a rolling basis to control credit risk. Led design and implementation and worked cross-functionally to ensure our solution behaved correctly across Stripe’s product offerings; built systems to monitor its execution (Ruby, Spark, MongoDB)
- Designed and got buy-in for a declarative merchant risk-policy system, which would extract business logic from code into human-readable rules that operations teams could edit without engineers
- One of two contributors on a six-month effort to build a manual assignment system to manage risk-related merchant reviews; in addition to dozens of new backend and frontend flows, designed a workload expectation model to predict required capacity (Ruby, JavaScript, React, MongoDB)
- Optimized our MongoDB oplog tailers, speeding up the indexing of their contents into an Elasticsearch cluster; introduced toggles to improve resilience to spikes in oplog volume
- Managed a summer intern; gathered requirements for monitoring news related to our merchants to detect cases of financial distress and oversaw its subsequent technical implementation

Wealthfront, Redwood City, CA
Software Engineer (Levels 1–3)

Aug 2014 – Oct 2017

- Received an annual “Top 10%” performance equity award for 2016
- Technical lead for Advanced Indexing, a three-month project staffed with six other full-stack engineers. Coordinated across functions to meet product and research requirements. Built a new framework to backtest our production code, oversaw the architecture of critical pieces of infrastructure, ensured team members met project milestones and presented status updates to our executive team (Java, R)
- Pitched and implemented an infrastructure project to reduce our daily cash exposure when trading client accounts, resulting in significantly reduced liability due to trading failures (Java, MySQL)
- Diagnosed and fixed choke points in our trading pipeline, yielding 20x speedups (Java, MySQL)
- Second developer on College Savings Plan (529), a yearlong project; worked closely with third parties to develop new integrations and architected numerous subsystems with an emphasis on fault-tolerant design. Built an integration-testing framework used by the entire team (Java, MySQL)
- Core contributor on Selling Plan, a product that sells down concentrated stock positions; worked cross-functionally with product, frontend and mobile to design and implement a clear API for eventual public release. Expanded trading to handle multiple share classes (Java, MySQL)
- Architected and guided the implementation of four intern projects that included real-time exception attribution through Git and the calculation of our management fees offline with Spark (Java, Spark)

REVIEWING & VOLUNTEERING

- **Reviewer:** NeurIPS 2026, ICML 2026 (Gold), INLG 2026, ICLR 2026, EACL SRW 2026, COLING 2025, ACL ARR (May 2026, Mar 2026, Jan 2026, Jul 2025, Feb 2025)
- **Volunteer Chair:** ICLR 2026

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

- **Fall 2022:** Head TA for Professor McKeown’s seminar on language generation, Columbia University
- **Fall 2021:** TA for Professor McKeown’s NLP course, Columbia University

SKILLS

Research: PyTorch, Hugging Face, PEFT, DeepSpeed, FSDP, vLLM, scikit-learn; SLURM; RL (GRPO, DPO, reward modeling); interpretability (steering, SAEs); LLM judges; human annotation design
Engineering: Python, Java, Ruby, JavaScript (React), Spark, MySQL, Postgres, MongoDB, Elasticsearch